

Tonality and atonality

Music that is in a definite major or minor key, or mode, is known as **tonal music**. Music that does not have a key signature is known as **atonal music**.

Is it in a key?

Most Western music is tonal, but many 20th- and 21st-century classical works are atonal. To decide whether or not music is in a key, look at the key signature, see if the music is organized around a keynote, and consider what accidentals are featured.

SEE ALSO

◀ 64–67 Keys

◀ 72–73 Accidentals

◀ 74–75 Modulation

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Tonal music	Atonal music	◀ Comparison This table shows the differences between tonal and atonal music. While tonal music has features that identify it with a particular key, atonal music lacks these features.
Has a key signature (unless the music is in C major or A minor)	No key signature	
Music is organized around the keynote, and usually starts and ends in the key suggested by the key signature	No sense that any one note is more important than the other in the music	
Any accidental is likely to be closely related to the key signature	Lots of accidentals that cannot be related back to a key in any logical way	

Tonal music

Shown here is an excerpt from Beethoven's *Pathétique* Piano Sonata—tonal music in the key of A $\flat$ major. It has a key signature, the keynote A $\flat$ features prominently in the music, and the accidentals involve modulations to keys that are closely related to A $\flat$ major.

Adagio cantabile

Keynote A $\flat$

Key signature of A $\flat$ major

Keynote A $\flat$

E $\flat$ leads to F in the next measure.

◀ **Beethoven's *Pathétique* Sonata**
This is the opening of the second movement of Beethoven's *Pathétique* Sonata. The key signature, keynote, and linked accidentals show that the music is tonal.

Keynote A $\flat$